



Sustainability & Climate Justice Commission Agenda

Date Monday, March 9th
 Time 5 pm
 Location City Hall Council Chambers
 Watch Online <https://www.youtube.com/@CityofIthacaPublicMeetings>

Item	Voting	Presenter	Time Allotted
1. Call to Order 1.1 Agenda Review	No	Aaron Fernando, Vice Chair	5
2. Public Comment 2.1 Statement from the Public 2.2 Commission Response	No No	Aaron Fernando, Vice Chair	10 5
3. Announcements, Reports & Presentations 3.1 Participatory Budget presentation	No	Siobhan Hull, staff	20
4. New Business 4.1 Commission structure and electing a chair 4.2 Recommendation to Common Council to adopt the Climate Action Plan	Yes Yes	Aaron Fernando, Vice Chair Aaron Fernando, Vice Chair	30 15
5. Meeting Wrap-up 5.1 Next Meeting: April 13th 5.2 Agenda Planning for Next Meeting 5.3 Adjournment	No No Yes	Aaron Fernando, Vice Chair	5



March S&CJ Commission

AGENDA

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Participatory Budget Review

JUSTICE50

In May 2024, Council adopted **Justice50** to create a framework for implementing the **equity** component of the IGND.

50% (at minimum) of total IGND program funding allocated to serve Climate Justice Communities (CJCs)	40% of participants in green jobs workforce training identify as climate justice individuals
50% (at minimum) of the City's total capital project budget serve Climate Justice Communities (CJCs)	10% of the City's total capital project budget allocated to participatory budgeting

WHY A PARTICIPATORY BUDGET?

Participatory budgeting allows residents to **imagine** and then determine which projects are **prioritized** and **funded** in their community. For climate justice communities who have historically been excluded from **decision making processes**, it can be an empowering opportunity to **build community resilience** and a **sense of shared responsibility** over the City.

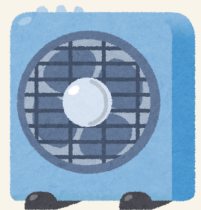
EXAMPLES IN OTHER CITIES

New York City (launched 2011)

\$30 million in 2026



Playground upgrades



Air conditioning in schools



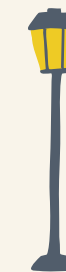
Upgrading community garden water system



School bathroom upgrades

Durham (launched 2018)

\$2.2 million in 2025



Lighting at parks



Pedestrian safety



Rec center equipment

HOW MUCH MONEY?

10% of the total Capital Project Budget is to be set aside for participatory budgeting.

This is what the Capital Project Budget has looked like in recent years:

2024	2025	2026
\$5,006,000	\$5,440,001	\$0

Challenging
budget year!



So ... participatory budgeting could involve around \$500,000 - depending on that year's budget!

HOW WILL IT WORK, BROADLY?

1. Proposing: City residents brainstorm and propose ideas for how to use the allocated budget within stated guidelines, as decided by City representatives and local laws.
2. Debating and Refining: Both the public and City representatives provide feedback on proposals; proposals are reviewed, discussed, and refined through a series of engagement efforts, such as forums, listening sessions, workshops, surveys, focus groups, or online engagement methods. The goal for this step is to have robust proposals ready for a public vote.
3. Voting: City residents vote on the final list of proposals.
4. Implementing: The City of Ithaca government implements the selected proposal(s). Best practice for this step is monitoring and reporting results back to community members.

HOW WILL IT BE DESIGNED?

Internal Staff Committee

1. Identify **legal guardrails** in process
 - a. Determine how PB funds can/cannot be spent in accordance with local and state law
 - b. If needed, identify alternative mechanisms for funds disbursement if a conflict is suspected
2. Identify **project approval process**
 - a. Recommend how projects will be pre-screened
 - b. Identify what, if any, approvals are needed once public voting has taken place (e.g. final Council vote)
3. Identify any additional necessary **stakeholders** (e.g. external entity to disburse funds)

Community Committee

1. Recommend a **voting process** (timeline, proposal review process, feedback process, review committee)
2. Recommend community's preferred **staff and Council roles** in implementation process
3. **Identify resources** residents may need to successfully submit proposals and potential groups/sources to provide those resources.
4. Identify an effective, and iterative, outreach and **engagement plan**.

Meeting every other
Thursday at 5pm - next
meetings are 3/12 and 3/26
at the library with a hybrid
option.

COMMUNITY COMMITTEE MEMBERS

- Armin Heurich - Ithaca City School District
- Taili Mugambée - Ultimate Re-entry Opportunity
- Ashley Cake - business community
- Niki Ray-Israelsohn - Bike Walk Tompkins
- Ace Dufresne - Sunrise Ithaca
- Harry Smith - Black Hands Universal
- Basil Ibrahim - previous Participatory Budget experience
- Katie Church - New Roots and food system work
- Chris Skawski - CCE liaison

We would like to have a **liaison** between the community participatory budget committee and the S&CJ commission.

Discussion of Commission Structure

PROPOSED STRUCTURE

- Elect a **Chair** and **Vice Chair** of the Commission
- **Rotate facilitation** of the meetings - have commission members sign up for the year ahead of time
- That month's facilitator joins the Chair and Vice Chair in an **agenda setting meeting** with the staff
- Is there interest in starting one or two **working groups**? Could have non-commission members participate. If there's interest, we can discuss more fully at a future meeting.

Discussion of Commission Recommendation of the CAP

DRAFT Sustainability & Climate Justice Commission Recommendation for Ithaca Common Council Adoption of the Climate Action Plan

[DATE]

Following the City of Ithaca's 2019 passage of the Ithaca Green New Deal (IGND) resolution and the subsequent legislative reaffirmation of this resolution in 2025, the City's Sustainability & Climate Justice Commission now recommends that Common Council vote on and adopt the Climate Action Plan prepared by Ithaca's Office of Sustainability.

This recommendation comes to Common Council from Ithaca's Sustainability & Climate Justice Commission, which was formed in [MONTH of YEAR] with "the purpose of providing Common Council and the City's Sustainability Office with advisory research, public input, and analysis for matters related to sustainability, climate justice and goals delineated in the IGND."

The recommending commission is made up of residents of this locality with professional and lived knowledge across domains including, energy, transportation, housing, financing, labor, public health, etc. who have reviewed this action plan through these lenses as well as our status as county and city residents. We offer our endorsement of the CAP based on our expertise and inherent interest in helping the City implement its sustainability and climate justice goals.

The 2019 IGND resolution committed the City to putting in place a Climate Action Plan (CAP) that would, "provide details on how to achieve the Ithaca Green New Deal." In effect—as members of Council will see—the CAP outlines a scope of work across a range of domains. Once passed, this will enable City staff to scale up the implementation of new and existing programs, and will provide a framework for the City's elected officials in grounding thinking about policies intended to benefit the City's residents, businesses, visitors, and ecology.

The recommended CAP impacts several sectors in our community. This breadth is intentional and matches the far-reaching nature of the issues the CAP necessarily addresses: climate change and its transformative effects on communities in Ithaca, as well as the physical and economic realities that affect these communities. Due to the complexity of these issues, the CAP touches upon six focus areas: housing, labor, public health, equity, power reliability, and emergency preparedness.

The CAP being put forth for your consideration does not simply outline methods of mitigating emissions that contribute to a destabilized climate. Rather, in alignment with best practices in the fields of energy and sustainability, the CAP takes a necessary step further to set our municipality up to meet expected climate-related challenges and shifting conditions, as well as address climate justice. Thus, the CAP contains recommendations that pertain to climate mitigation and climate adaptation and climate justice. This is important to note: the climate

adaptation recommendations included in the CAP are intended to indicate courses of action and legislative policies *likely to help* those who live and work in our municipality as they adjust to the many and diverse effects driven by climate change.

Over the past two years, the City's Sustainability Director and staff has actively sought insight and feedback from beyond the Commission as well. The Sustainability Office also sought public input through different forms of engagement, including:

- A public survey focused on labor and housing
- A public survey focused on public health and racial equity
- A public survey focused on emergency preparedness and electrical reliability
- In-person outreach events at the public library and on the Ithaca Commons
- Public comments during meetings of the Sustainability & Climate Justice Commission

This commission has reviewed the proposed Climate Action Plan, and now sees fit to recommend its adoption by the Common Council of the City of Ithaca.

The Sustainability & Climate Justice Commission recommends that members of Ithaca Common Council review the Climate Action Plan thoroughly, and adopt it as swiftly as possible, so that the next steps in implementation of the Ithaca Green New Deal may commence.

Signed,
The Sustainability and Climate Justice Commission
[LIST NAMES]